

The more the futures business evolved, the less agriculture had anything to do with it. In 1982, the Board of Trade added its stock-index futures. In New York, the Comex and the New York Futures Exchange improvised their own financial futures, then options, then options on the futures. No longer could you tell by the official name of an exchange what its business was. The Coffee, Sugar, and Cocoa Exchange traded Consumer Price Index futures.

The action in the last 10 years made the previous 100 seem but a lazy prelude to furious and spectacular advancements. With trading volume up fivefold across the industry, at last count there were 53,000 registered salespeople working for 383 brokerage houses, 6,000 floor brokers, 1,200 commodity pool operators, 2,100 trading advisors, for a total of 65,000 professionals in futures. This was what I was up against.